learning disability autism policy

Version: 1.0 | Effective: | Review:

---

title: "Learning Disability and Autism-Specific Policy" effectiveDate: "" reviewDate: "" version: "1.0"

Learning Disability and Autism-Specific Policy

1. Policy Statement

At [INSERT CARE HOME NAME], we are committed to providing person-centred, compassionate, and inclusive care for individuals with learning disabilities and/or autism. We recognise the diverse needs of people with these conditions and aim to deliver support that promotes dignity, independence, choice, and wellbeing.

Our approach is guided by:

- The Human Rights Act 1998 and equality legislation
- The Care Act 2014 and Health and Social Care Act 2008
- The Autism Act 2009 and Think Autism strategy
- The principles of Respect, Inclusion, and Person-Centred Care

2. Purpose

This policy ensures that:

- Residents with learning disabilities and/or autism receive tailored care that respects their individual needs, strengths, and preferences.
- Barriers to communication, participation, and inclusion are identified and addressed.
- Staff are equipped with the knowledge and skills to support residents effectively.
- Safeguarding, dignity, and rights are upheld at all times.

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- All residents with a learning disability and/or autism at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME]
- All staff, volunteers, and contractors working with these residents
- Families, advocates, and external professionals involved in care planning and support

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Registered Manager:

- Ensures compliance with legislation, regulatory requirements, and best practice guidance.
- Oversees staff training in learning disability and autism awareness.
- Ensures care plans are personalised, inclusive, and regularly reviewed. Staff:
- Deliver care and support in line with each resident’s individual care plan.

- Promote communication, inclusion, and independence.
- Report concerns about behaviour, safeguarding, or wellbeing promptly. Residents and Families/Advocates:
- Are actively involved in care planning and decision-making.
- Are encouraged to express preferences, wishes, and feedback on care.

5. Key Care Principles 5.1 Person-Centred Care

- Care plans are tailored to the individual's needs, abilities, preferences, and goals.
- Residents are supported to make choices and be actively involved in daily life.
- Family and advocates are consulted where appropriate. 5.2 Communication
- Staff use appropriate communication tools (e.g., Makaton, PECS, visual aids).
- Information is provided in accessible formats (Easy Read, pictorial).
- Residents are given extra time and support to understand and respond. 5.3 Environment
- The home environment is adapted to reduce sensory overload (e.g., noise, lighting).
- Safe and calming spaces are available for residents.
- Clear signage and structured routines are promoted where helpful. 5.4 Positive Behaviour Support (PBS)
- Behaviours of concern are understood in the context of unmet needs or communication difficulties.
- Proactive and preventative strategies are used to reduce distress.
- Restrictive practices are avoided unless absolutely necessary and always proportionate, recorded, and reviewed. 5.5 Health and Wellbeing
- Residents are supported to access healthcare, screenings, and annual health checks.
- Reasonable adjustments are made when attending medical appointments.
- Staff are alert to diagnostic overshadowing (attributing all health issues to disability).

6. Safeguarding

- Residents with learning disabilities and/or autism may be at increased risk of abuse or neglect.
- All staff must follow the Safeguarding Adults Policy and report concerns immediately.
- Advocacy services will be offered to ensure residents' rights and voices are upheld.

7. Staff Training and Awareness

- All staff will receive mandatory training in learning disability and autism awareness, in line with the Oliver McGowan Mandatory Training in Learning Disability and Autism framework.
- Refresher training will be provided regularly.

- Specialist training (e.g., communication methods, PBS) will be provided where required.

8. Involvement and Inclusion

- Residents are encouraged to participate in activities, decision-making, and community life.
- Reasonable adjustments are made to ensure inclusion.
- Cultural, religious, and personal preferences are respected.

9. Monitoring and Review

- Care plans will be regularly reviewed with input from residents, families, and professionals.
- Audits of care delivery, staff training, and resident feedback will be conducted.
- This policy will be reviewed annually or sooner if guidance changes.

10. References

- Autism Act 2009
- Care Act 2014
- Health and Social Care Act 2008 (Regulated Activities) Regulations 2014
- NHS England: Building the Right Support (2015)
- CQC Key Lines of Enquiry (KLOEs)
- NICE Guidelines: Autism spectrum disorder in adults (CG142) & Learning disability and behaviour that challenges (NG11)

11. Related Policies

- Safeguarding Adults Policy
- Equality, Diversity, and Inclusion Policy
- Communication Policy
- Positive Behaviour Support / Restraint Policy
- Health and Wellbeing Policy

Generated by Docuflow